

THE CROOKED STONE AND THE THORNWALD STANDARD

O hush, hush now, the marsh-wind sighs, Where drowned reeds bow
beneath grey skies; Let no man swear what waits beyond The broken
palisade and pond.

For Crookgate Keep stands grim and lean, Against the Weeping
Marshes' mien; Its stones wear rain, its towers stare Through
vapour, mud, and rotting air.

Founded in 294 AS, It keeps no peace, grants no redress; Contested
still, it holds its ground Where uncertain waters crawl around.

It lies outside the realm's core holdings, Beyond the bells and
guarded mouldings; No lord may claim its stones by right, Nor name
its shadow day or night.

Some say the walls remember feet, Some say the gate has learned
deceit; I say the keep has neither tongue— Yet every door is
listening.

O hush, hush now, the marsh-wind grieves, It combs the rushes,
shakes the eaves; At Crookgate, truth is thin as thread, And every
path may end among the dead.

But hear another burden rise, Beneath the iron-coloured skies: A
standard lifted, straight and high, A solemn mark that will not fly.

Isolde Thornwald bears it still— So sings the road, so wills the
hill; Isolde Thornwald, Standard-Bearer, With formal step and
shoulders fairer.

Born in 272 AS, She learned no bow to ease distress; Her face is
set, her bearing plain, Her hands hold fast through wind and rain.

Not for the feast, nor lordly hall, Not for the trumpet's idle call;
She stands where watching eyes are turned, While lesser courage
folds and burns.

The cloth may snap, the dark may roar, The mud may clutch the
standard's floor; Still does she raise that sign above The nameless
fear, the faithless love.

O Crookgate stone, O thorn-marked sign, Your fates are joined in

song, not mine; I bind you here with cord of rhyme, Though no man
bind the marsh or time.

The keep stands watch in uncertain weather, The standard bears its
burden better; One is a fortress, stark and old, One is a vow that
will not fold.

If Crookgate falls, let no bell toll— The marsh keeps count within
its soul. If Isolde's standard dims at last, Sing not that
steadfastness has passed.

For stones may sink in soaking ground, And banners tear without a
sound; Yet while one throat remembers clear, The keep and standard
both are near.

So hush, hush now, you reed and rain, Carry this song through mist
and pain: Crookgate Keep, where doubts abide— Isolde Thornwald,
standing wide.